Voice and Politics:

Suppression, Accumulation, and Explosion

Macharia Barii

October 25, 2026

Abstract

This paper argues that voice (v_i^e) is the pressure valve of the ledger. Politics is endogenous to relations of reciprocity, and when actors possess legitimate channels to articulate grievances and propose alternatives to the status quo, the injustice gap (G) can be corrected through reform. However, when those channels are suppressed, atomized, or captured, grievances do not disappear. They are driven underground. Through a process of accumulation, latent discontent solidifies into parallel networks of trust, alternative narratives, and clandestine organization. These underground movements persist beneath the surface of apparent stability, growing in size and cohesion the more repressive the attempt to silence them becomes. Eventually, once a critical threshold is crossed, this accumulated pressure explodes into open contention in the form of protests, insurrections, revolutions, or wars. Drawing from the ledger framework in conversation with Hirschman's *Exit, Voice, and Loyalty*, Scott's *Arts of Resistance*, and theories of revolutionary crisis, this paper demonstrates that suppressing voice is not a strategy of long-term pacification, but one of deferred violence. The surest way to prevent revolutionary explosion is not repression, but the institutionalization of robust, credible channels of voice.

Keywords: voice, suppression, underground movements, accumulation, revolution, war, exit, loyalty, atomization, ledger, legitimacy

Contents

1 Introduction **2**

2 Voice in the Ledger Framework **2**

3 Mechanisms of Suppression **2**

4 Grievance Accumulation and the Underground **3**

5 From Accumulation to Explosion **4**

6 The Irony of Repression **4**

7 Institutionalizing Voice to Prevent Explosion **5**

8 Conclusion **6**

9 References **6**

1 Introduction

Every stable order must answer a simple question: where do grievances go? As established by the ledger framework, any relation with $s_i^e \in (0,1)$ and $k_i^e < \infty$ generates political activity. Actors that find themselves beneath their acceptance threshold $\bar{a}_i$ possess an incentive to alter the terms of their relation through the instruments available to them; voice, exit, coercion, or appeal to a third party [1, 2].

Of these instruments, voice is the most reformative. Where credible channels exist, grievances can be aggregated into claims ($P(S)$), negotiated over, and potentially realized by governance ($G(S)$). This allows for the rebalancing of the ledger without rupturing the order itself.

However, history consistently demonstrates the inverse. When voice is foreclosed, the pressure does not dissipate. It is redirected. What cannot be said in public is whispered in private. What cannot be organized openly is organized clandestinely. What cannot be bargained for through legitimate institutions is hoarded until the cost of inaction exceeds the cost of rebellion. Suppressing voice is, therefore, not the removal of conflict, but its temporal displacement. The longer it is suppressed, the more compressed and volatile it becomes [10, 15, 17].

2 Voice in the Ledger Framework

Within the ledger, voice is more than the act of speaking. It is the capacity to affect the terms of relation.

Definition 2.1 (Voice)**.** *Voice (v_i^e) is the degree to which an actor can meaningfully articulate grievances, propose alternatives, and compel consideration of their claims within a given relation e. It is a structural parameter, not merely a matter of free speech in principle, but of efficacy in practice [10, 2].*

The efficacy of voice is directly tied to the other parameters of the ledger. Where exit costs (k_i^e) are low and viable alternatives exist, voice is strengthened by credibility. Where exit costs are exorbitantly high, voice is often forced, yet simultaneously made more desperate by the lack of an alternative. Where legitimacy (L) is high, voice is readily aggregated by institutions. Where legitimacy is low, institutions filter, dilute, or dismiss it entirely [10, 1].

Crucially, voice is what keeps $P(S)$ open. A healthy political order is one in which the set of circulating claims is a genuine reflection of the distribution of grievance throughout society. A captured order is one in which $P(S)$ is narrowed to the preferences of the sustaining coalition, whilst the claims of the majority are barred entry [1, 2].

3 Mechanisms of Suppression

The foreclosure of voice rarely takes the form of a total ban on speech. More often, it is a combination of subtle and coercive mechanisms that raise the private cost of contestation whilst maintaining a veneer of legitimacy [15, 21].

- **Institutional capture.** Unions are gutted, opposition parties are gerrymandered into irrelevance, courts are stacked, and avenues for appeal are rendered procedurally futile. The form of representation remains, however its function as an aggregator of claims is destroyed [14, 1].

- **Atomization.** Precarity, gig work, spatial segregation, and mass surveillance all serve to isolate actors from one another. Without dense networks of trust, grievances remain individualized. What would be a class-wide claim is instead internalized as individual failure, preventing the collective action necessary for voice to scale [2, 21].
- **Co-optation and factionalism.** Select representatives are brought into the apparatus, minor concessions are doled out to divide movements, and identity is weaponized to pit groups with shared material interests against one another. This fractures potential coalitions and prevents the consolidation of a broad base of opposition [15, 17].
- **Chilling through fear.** Surveillance, SLAPP suits, blacklisting, arbitrary arrest, and selective enforcement create a climate of fear. Actors rationally self-censor, knowing that the line between legitimate protest and "subversion" is malleable and applied disproportionately to those challenging the ledger [3, 21].
- **Narrative naturalization.** As explored in *Religion and Politics*, narratives of tradition, patriotism, merit, or providence are utilized to frame the status quo as inevitable or divinely ordained. Dissent is recast as ingratitude, treason, or heresy. This raises the social cost of voice in addition to the legal and physical ones [4, 6].

Individually, these mechanisms are manageable. Together, they form a system designed to keep $P(S)$ artificially narrow whilst the true ledger grows increasingly skewed.

4 Grievance Accumulation and the Underground

When public voice is foreclosed, a dialectical shift occurs. Grievances leave the formal political sphere and enter the hidden transcript [15].

Proposition 4.1 (Suppression breeds accumulation)**.** *The rate of grievance accumulation is inversely proportional to the credibility of public channels of voice. The more costly it is to voice a claim openly, the greater the incentive to store, verify, and collectively validate that claim in private.*

This process occurs in predictable stages. First, *validation*: actors discover in hushed conversation that their individualized struggles are, in fact, shared. Second, *solidarity*: trust is built through acts of mutual aid, care work, and protection from repression. These acts of reciprocity rebuild the social fabric that atomization sought to destroy [15, 13]. Third, *parallel organization*: clandestine cells, study circles, worker committees, neighborhood networks, or religiously autonomous groups emerge to coordinate resources and disseminate information outside of state controlled mediums. Fourth, *counter-hegemony*: alternative narratives are constructed that accurately diagnose the ledger, assign responsibility to the coalition, and articulate a vision for rebalancing it [9, 15].

These underground movements are not inherently violent. In fact, the vast majority of them spend the bulk of their existence in this phase of accumulation; teaching, feeding, hiding, documenting, and organizing. They are a product of the order's refusal to listen. The state often mistakes this silence for consent, failing to recognize that the apparent peace is the product of repression, not legitimacy [15, 17].

5 From Accumulation to Explosion

Apparent stability is brittle. A ledger can remain skewed for decades, however, every act of repression, every dismissed grievance, and every broken promise adds weight to the accumulated pressure. This pressure is not linear. It is latent until a spark renders the cost of continued inaction unbearable [5, 17].

Proposition 5.1 (Suppressed voice explodes)**.** *When the perceived costs of open rebellion fall below the perceived costs of continued silent suffering, the underground erupts into mass contention. The magnitude of this explosion is proportional to the duration and intensity of prior suppression.*

Several factors catalyze this crossing of the rupture threshold (ρ_i) for large swathes of the population simultaneously.

- **A legitimacy crisis.** A scandal, electoral theft, military blunder, or the openly callous response to a tragedy can shatter the narrative of benevolent rule. The coalition is revealed to be exactly what the underground had been saying all along [5, 20].
- **A shift in the balance of fear.** Acts of courage are contagious. The arrest of one organizer, the image of a single protester, or the successful defense of a community can rapidly diffuse. Once a critical mass no longer believes that dissent is individually suicidal, the calculations of rationality invert en masse [11, 18].
- **Economic shocks.** Price spikes, austerity, mass layoffs, or the stripping of basic goods expose the parasitism of the ledger with brutal clarity. As argued in *Democracy and the Four Freedoms*, freedom from want is necessary for voice to remain non-coercive. When it is revoked for the many to protect the shares of the few, desperation overrides fear [3, 5].
- **Factional splits within the elite.** Revolutions are rarely made by the masses alone. When a portion of the apparatus, bureaucracy, or military loses faith in the coalition or defects out of self-preservation, the coercive capacity of Gov fractures. At this moment, the underground finds the space to go overt [16, 18].

What follows is not spontaneous chaos, but the rapid politicization of years worth of work. Neighborhood defense committees become de-facto governance, mutual aid becomes provisioning, and underground cells become public organizations. The claims that were once unspeakable flood into the open all at once. Depending on the response of the apparatus, this can manifest as a mass reform movement, a revolution that seeks to reconstitute the ledger, a civil war over competing visions of it, or, in the worst cases, a war of annihilation as the coalition desperately clings onto its λ vector at all costs [5, 16, 17].

6 The Irony of Repression

The logic of suppression is fundamentally shortsighted. The coalition reasons that crushing dissent now prevents unrest later. In reality, the inverse is true.

Repression is informative. Every raid reveals the coalition's fear of organization. Every unjust sentence validates the underground's analysis of the law as an instrument for reproducing the ledger rather than administering justice. Every act of brutality radicalizes those that may have otherwise only sought reform [15, 18].

Furthermore, repression selects for more clandestine, more disciplined, and often, more militant forms of organization. Public moderates are silenced or driven out of the open sphere, whilst those willing to operate underground gain prominence. The movement becomes less easily co-optable, more distrustful of negotiation, and far less willing to settle for partial concessions upon eruption [8, 18].

This is the great irony: the tools utilized to prevent revolution are some of the greatest producers of revolutionary conditions. A government that refuses to hear voices in the legislature will, eventually, be forced to hear them in the streets, in the barracks, and on the battlefield. Stability bought through fear is always borrowed time [1, 17].

7 Institutionalizing Voice to Prevent Explosion

If suppression breeds explosion, then prevention is the institutionalization of credible voice. This is not appeasement, but structural maintenance of the ledger.

1. **Expand aggregative channels.** Strong, independent unions, proportional representation, accessible avenues for direct democracy, and protected assembly all allow for claims to enter $P(S)$ before they reach a boiling point [7, 1].

2. **Equalize exit and voice.** As established in previous work, asymmetries in k_i^e and v_i^e are the root of capture. Equalizing exit costs through universal basic services, robust labor protections, and material security allows voice to be exercised without coercion. Expanding voice to the atomized ensures that no class is forced into the underground by desperation [1, 10].

3. **Protect the watchdogs.** An independent press, protected legal aid, and autonomous civil society act as early warning systems. They make the injustice gap legible before it becomes ungovernable, allowing for reform whilst G is still within a range that is correctable without rupture [3, 12].

4. **Enforce the distinction between critique and crime.** Dissent must remain political, not treasonous. Broad, vague charges of "sedition" or "destabilization" are the hallmark of a regime attempting to criminalize the pressure valve itself. A government secure in its legitimacy can afford to be criticized. One that cannot, is already on the path towards substituting repression for it [1, 20].

5. **Institutionalize feedback.** Genuine reform requires that governance ($G(S)$) be responsive to the claims that politics produces. Consultation without consequence breeds cynicism. Concessions only obtained through repression breed contempt. Credible, iterative rebalancing is the only way to keep the ledger within the viability set V without resorting to constant crisis management [1, 13].

The goal is not the absence of conflict. Conflict is endemic to the ledger. The goal is to keep conflict political. Politics is the contestation of shares, costs, and voice through words, negotiation, and organization. War, revolution, and insurrection are politics by other means, pursued only when all political means have been foreclosed [19, 17].

8 Conclusion

Voice is the pressure valve of civilization. Where it is open, grievance can be vented, aggregated, and corrected. Where it is welded shut by fear, capture, and repression, pressure builds beneath the surface. The underground is not a product of malice, it is a product of exclusion. Solidarity forged in clandestinity, narratives forged in hiding, and organization forged under threat accumulate until the ledger becomes unsustainable to maintain by force alone.

The explosion of violence is not irrational, nor is it proof of the inherent wickedness of the oppressed. It is the delayed consequence of a political order refusing to listen whilst it still could have negotiated. Suppressing voice does not grant permanence, it grants latency. Every revolution is, in essence, a history of suppressed speech finally finding its volume.

A civilization that wishes to avoid war and revolution must choose a different path. It must not ask how to silence its dissidents more effectively, but how to hear them sooner. It must treat grievance as information rather than insubordination, and rebalancing as governance rather than concession. The preservation of order lies not in the strength of its prisons, but in the credibility of its forums. Open the channels of voice, or be forced to reckon with their closure.

9 References

References

[1] Barii, M. (2026a). *Politics, Governance, and Government in the Ledger Framework.* Unpublished manuscript.

[2] Barii, M. (2026b). *Principles of Politics and War: A Citizen's Guide to the Contest Over the Ledger.* Unpublished manuscript.

[3] Barii, M. (2026c). *Democracy and the Four Freedoms: A Ledger Account.* Unpublished manuscript.

[4] Barii, M. (2026d). *Religion and Politics: A Ledger Account.* Unpublished manuscript.

[5] Brinton, C. (1938). *The Anatomy of Revolution.* Revised edition. New York: Vintage Books, 1965.

[6] Casanova, J. (1994). *Public Religions in the Modern World.* Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

[7] Dahl, R. A. (1971). *Polyarchy: Participation and Opposition.* New Haven: Yale University Press.

[8] Della Porta, D. (1995). *Social Movements, Political Violence, and the State: A Comparative Analysis of Italy and Germany.* Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

[9] Gramsci, A. (1971). *Selections from the Prison Notebooks.* Ed. and trans. Q. Hoare and G. N. Smith. New York: International Publishers.

[10] Hirschman, A. O. (1970). *Exit, Voice, and Loyalty: Responses to Decline in Firms, Organizations, and States.* Cambridge: Harvard University Press.

[11] Lohmann, S. (1994). "The Dynamics of Informational Cascades: The Monday Demonstrations in Leipzig, East Germany, 1989-91". *World Politics*, 47(1), 42–101.

[12] North, D. C. (1990). *Institutions, Institutional Change and Economic Performance*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

[13] Ostrom, E. (1990). *Governing the Commons: The Evolution of Institutions for Collective Action*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

[14] Pistor, K. (2019). *The Code of Capital: How the Law Creates Wealth and Inequality*. Princeton: Princeton University Press.

[15] Scott, J. C. (1990). *Domination and the Arts of Resistance: Hidden Transcripts*. New Haven: Yale University Press.

[16] Skocpol, T. (1979). *States and Social Revolutions: A Comparative Analysis of France, Russia, and China*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

[17] Tilly, C. (1978). *From Mobilization to Revolution*. Reading: Addison-Wesley.

[18] Tilly, C. (2003). *The Politics of Collective Violence*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

[19] von Clausewitz, C. (1832). *On War*. Ed. and trans. M. Howard and P. Paret. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1976.

[20] Weber, M. (1919). "Politics as a Vocation". In *Max Weber: Essays in Sociology*, trans. H. H. Gerth and C. W. Mills. New York: Oxford University Press, 1946.

[21] Zuboff, S. (2019). *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism: The Fight for a Human Future at the New Frontier of Power*. New York: PublicAffairs.